

Diversion Programs & Restorative Justice

Learner guide | SWP-023 | School of Criminal Justice & Forensic Social Work

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Diversion Programs & Restorative Justice. By the end of the course, you should be able to describe suitable diversion and restorative approaches and their safeguards.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Describe suitable diversion and restorative approaches and their safeguards.
- Apply the key ideas from Alternatives to incarceration.
- Apply the key ideas from Restorative justice principles.
- Apply the key ideas from Case coordination.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Alternatives to incarceration	eligibility, aims, equity, community-based support, and evidence	10 to 15 minutes
2. Restorative justice principles	voluntary participation, accountability, repair, victim safety, and facilitator neutrality	10 to 15 minutes
3. Case coordination	referral, service plans, monitoring, completion, and avoiding net widening	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Alternatives to incarceration

This module focuses on eligibility, aims, equity, community-based support, and evidence. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Eligibility
- Aims
- Equity
- Community-based support
- Evidence

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of alternatives to incarceration in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of eligibility, aims, equity, community-based support, and evidence. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through alternatives to incarceration safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Restorative justice principles

This module focuses on voluntary participation, accountability, repair, victim safety, and facilitator neutrality. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Voluntary participation
- Accountability
- Repair
- Victim safety
- Facilitator neutrality

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of restorative justice principles in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of voluntary participation, accountability, repair, victim safety, and facilitator neutrality. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through restorative justice principles safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Case coordination

This module focuses on referral, service plans, monitoring, completion, and avoiding net widening. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Referral
- Service plans
- Monitoring
- Completion
- Avoiding net widening

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of case coordination in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of referral, service plans, monitoring, completion, and avoiding net widening. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through case coordination safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: eligibility.
- Review the distinction between: consent.
- Review the distinction between: victim safety.
- Review the distinction between: programme safeguards.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.